

roleplay, with some of the best character development coming out of mistakes, mishaps, and foul-ups.

Example: *Your character is crawling through the vents of a laboratory complex. As your sluagh creeps through the steel shaft, he feels a sheet of metal depress under his knee. The Storyteller tells you to roll your character's Dexterity + Stealth (difficulty 7). You roll and the dice turn up 2, 3, 3, 5, 6 — no successes. The Storyteller narrates that as you shift your weight, the metal below your knee "clangs", reverberating throughout the vent. Thankfully, the vent didn't collapse into the lab below, but you don't know if any of the scientists or guards heard the noise.*

Failure should not represent a sudden stop to a story, but instead should present an array of possibilities to the player who failed. It should not injure a character as much as imperil him, or make a route of inquiry more difficult to pursue. A failed attempt to seduce a fellow in a bar might result in a rejection, but not a hot drink being thrown in the face of the changeling who asked.

Botches

Sometimes it's just not a changeling's day. When the dice show a 1, the result is severe enough to cancel out a success. Take the die showing 1 and one of the dice showing a success — starting with the lowest numbered success — and set them aside. In this manner, an otherwise successful action may be reduced to failure, with multiple results of 1 cancelling out multiple successes.

If none of the dice show as successes *and* one or more dice shows 1, the roll is a botch. If you score at least one success, even if that success is canceled out and additional 1s remain, it's just a simple failure.

A botch is much worse than a normal failure — it's dramatic misfortune. Botching a Law roll when defending a client may result in their receiving a harsher penalty than they deserve. Botching a Survival roll may result in a tracker following her footprints in a circle for hours. Botching a Brawl roll means a street fighter doesn't just miss his opponent, he breaks the bones in his hand against the wall, and the fight continues on. The Storyteller decides exactly what goes wrong.

Example: *Your character spies on a gang of youths, having been informed one of them is a "sleeping" changeling. Watching a young lad from afar, you roll your character's Perception + Kenning (difficulty 6), aiming to tell if this exuberant boy is in fact a changeling who's yet to achieve Chrysalis, getting 1, 1, 4, 5, 8. The one success is cancelled out, but the remaining 1 doesn't count as a botch. The changeling is unable to tell if the child is in fact one of the Kithain.*

Aware of the number of people around in this area, you decide your character continues her reconnaissance while disguising her acts and blending into the crowd. You roll an Appearance + Stealth (difficulty 5) to become another face in the background, getting 1, 2, 4. This time you score no successes and the single 1 results in a botch. Not only does your character fail to remain inconspicuous, she draws the attention of a concerned citizen who grabs her wrist and loudly accuses her of staring at those children for a little too long...



Optional Rule: Fear of Failure



Sometimes players fail rolls a little too often. An occasional botch keeps a game interesting. Repeated botches risk compounding a feeling of failure, and can freeze a plot if dice rolls prevent characters from moving forward.

If you find players are failing rolls too much and you want a slightly more forgiving take on the system, remove the rule of 1s cancelling successes. 1s now only count as botches where zero successes appear. Players may spend a Willpower point to remove the chance of botching.



Botches should be creative and further the story, even if it is in an unexpected way. They should be dramatic enough to cause knock-on effects further down the line of the chronicle, and be the kinds of mishaps and strokes of bad fortune the motley eventually jokes or commiserates about. Sometimes a botch occurs in such a dramatic way as to signify the overwhelming strength of an opponent, or a rival's simple luck in beating the changelings at their own game.

Queen Aeron of Pacifica's guardian white lion mauled the troll knight while he attempted to mollify her temperamental cats. He botched the attempt to pacify her pets, and is now the laughingstock of the Court. The nocker scholar's quiet, savant student humiliated her in a botched examination. Kithain whisper the tale in all corners of the nocker's library as the changeling seethes. A spriggan nurse misdiagnosed a bout of food poisoning as an attempted assassination, leading to the implosion of the local Unseelie Court. She's now hunted far and wide. All such examples rank as grand misadventures due to botches. Botches should lead to fresh and dangerous tales, with thrilling anecdotes as the result.

Automatic Success

Rolling dice isn't always necessary, especially when a character is so adept at a particular task that involving a chance of failure would break the game's immersion. Anything that streamlines play and reduces distractions is a good thing. **Changeling** employs a simple system for automatic successes, allowing rolling to be skipped for mundane actions.

If the number of dice in a dice pool is equal to or greater than the difficulty number, the character automatically succeeds with no dice rolled. This doesn't work in a dynamic or stressful situation, and automatic successes are always considered marginal (one success). Therefore, if a character is attempting a trick shot or the construction of her magnum opus, it may be worth rolling to succeed anyhow.

When the stakes are high, a player can also spend a Willpower point (see p. 258). Doing so grants a single success, reducing the chance of a botch. Only one Willpower point can be spent per turn and must be declared prior to rolling dice.

